SEMPLICE ITALIAN KITCHEN | BUDGET-FRIENDLY ITALIAN

Authentic Neapolitan Pasta e Patate con Provola (One-Pot Creamy Potato & Cheese Pasta)

PREP: 10 mins | COOK: 25 mins | TOTAL: 35 mins | SERVINGS: 4 servings ($1.55/serving) | CALORIES: 510 kcal

INGREDIENTS

* 600g (1.3 lbs) Yukon Gold Potatoes (peeled and cut into small 1/2-inch (1.2cm) cubes)
* 320g (11 oz) Pasta Mista (Mixed Short Pasta) or Ditalini (uncooked)
* 200g (7 oz) Smoked Provola (Provola Affumicata) or Smoked Scamorza (cut into 1/2-inch cubes, at room temperature)
* 1 small Yellow Onion, 1 Carrot & 1 Celery Rib (finely minced for soffritto)
* 50g (2 oz) Pancetta or Guanciale (Optional) (finely diced, or use 3 tbsp olive oil for vegetarian)
* 3 tbsp (45ml) Extra-Virgin Olive Oil
* 2 tbsp Cherry Tomato Passata or Triple Tomato Paste (for classic Neapolitan amber hue)
* 1 sprig Fresh Rosemary & 1 Parmigiano-Reggiano Rind
* 50g (1/2 cup) Parmigiano-Reggiano DOP (finely grated)
* 1.2 Liters (5 cups) Hot Vegetable Broth or Water

STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Saut the Soffritto & Rosemary Base (5 mins)

Warm the olive oil (and optional diced pancetta) in a heavy Dutch oven over medium heat. Add the finely minced onion, carrot, celery, and rosemary sprig, cooking for 5 minutes until soft and golden.

Step 2: Sear the Potatoes & Simmer with Parmigiano Rind (12 mins)

Add the cubed potatoes and tomato passata (or paste), stirring for 3 minutes to coat the potatoes in the savory base. Pour in enough hot broth (about 3.5 cups) to cover the potatoes by 1 inch, drop in the Parmigiano rind, and simmer gently for 12 minutes until the potatoes are fork-tender. Mash about 20% of the potatoes against the side of the pot to thicken the base.

Step 3: Cook the Pasta Directly in the Potato Broth ("Risottare") (10 mins)

Pour the uncooked Pasta Mista (or ditalini) directly into the simmering potato pot along with the remaining hot broth. Cook over medium heat for 9-10 minutes, stirring frequently like a risotto so the starches marry into a thick, creamy ("azzeccata") consistency.

Step 4: Rest 2 Minutes Off Heat Before Adding Provola (3 mins)

Turn off the stove completely, remove the rosemary sprig, and let the pot rest uncovered for 2 full minutes so the temperature drops slightly. Add the grated Parmigiano and cubed smoked provola, stirring gently from the bottom up until the cheese melts into long, stretchy ribbons.

Step 5: Garnish with Cracked Black Pepper & Serve (1 mins)

Ladle into warm bowls, top with a generous grind of coarse black pepper and a thread of raw olive oil, and serve immediately while the cheese pulls.

NONNA’S CHEF TIPS:

- Never skip the 2-minute rest off the heat before adding smoked provola! Boiling temperatures shock stretched-curd cheeses and make them stringy instead of velvety.
- Mashing a few spoonfuls of cooked potato cubes directly against the Dutch oven wall creates instant creaminess before the pasta even goes in.